
The Power of Mary in Trinidad **Inspiration and Seduction for the Colonial Construction of Religions**

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Note

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Introduction

Among the personal mementos of late Father John Pius Dowling, Archbishop of POS from 1909 to 1940, is a framed photograph of now almost forgotten *La Divina Pastora* in Trinidad, distinct from *La Divina Pastora* at Siparia who has drawn the faithful to her reputed curative power. On the back of the picture, a handwritten caption says in Portuguese:

Image of Our Lady, honored under the title of La Divina Pastora in the mother church of Arouca
[Imagem de Nossa Senhora, honrada debaixo do título de 'La Divina Pastora' na igreja matriz de Arouca].”

These two *La Divina Pastoras* have intersected, competed, and collided. Tracing their biographies reveals how Marian image has inspired and disordered the hegemonic, patriarchal production and governance of the religious boundaries in colonial Trinidad. It also sheds light on the intricate power relations of the Catholic Church, an obvious yet overlooked fact when *La Divina Pastora* devotion is examined, and intra-Catholic conflict over this Marian image, which has been the object of adoration for Hindus.

Ecology of Marian Devotion

The historical formation and transformation of *La Divina Pastora* devotion remain opaque to our view until their contexts, including the religious landscape and location of Marian devotion within it, are more thoroughly explored revisiting how and when questions.

Post-Emancipation Trinidad was marked by the politics of position between the Catholic Church and rising Protestant missionaries. Published in 1844, the Ecclesiastical Ordinance aggravated the intra-Christian relationship. By the 1870s, the Catholic Church forced a concession from the colonial state to repeal the Ordinance and disestablish the Anglican Church. But the Catholic-Protestant rivalry remained strong and their politics of representation endured well into the 20th century.

Amid the Catholic-Protestant conflict, the Catholic Diocese came under the leadership of the Dominican Order with the arrival of French Dominican Louis Gonin as the 4th Archbishop of Port-of-Spain in 1864. For over a century afterwards, three Irish Dominicans (Patrick Vincent

Flood, 1889–1907; Dowling, 1909–1940; and Finber Ryan, 1940–1968) succeeded to the archbishopric. During their tenure, more than two hundred Irish Dominicans and thirty French Dominicans held most of the important offices in the archdiocese and priesthood for the principal parishes in the colony.

The Protestant missionaries referred to Marian devotion as representative of the moral degeneracy of Roman Catholicism, expounding their views on Mariolatry that Catholics held in idolatrous reverence to the Virgin Mary, more than paying respect for the Mother as the mediator to God. They contended that this non-sacrificial type of reverence (*dulia* in Latin) was disrespectful and sexually-debauched, having degraded the canonical interpretation of the Scripture and deviated Christian devotion away from the Holy Trinity (*latria*). For instance, in 1855, the year when the Catholic-Protestant tension run high with the arrival of English-illiterate Archbishop Vincent Spaccapietra, *The Church of England Magazine* published a commentary by a clergy in the colony, entitled “Mariolatry in Trinidad”:

Never was the spirit of antichrist more wickedly busy in subverting the worship of the one only Mediator, and substituting that of his human parent, than in these “last days.” In a preceding column we have seen to what an extent this false worship is becoming... the corner-stone of the papal apostasy: I will now contrast with it, on the authority of a pious and exemplary clergy man in Trinidad, the working of that apostasy amongst its votaries in the west: “The Romish bishop has made great efforts to pervert our people; and the doings of the priests have been such as to excite the attention of one of our legislators. Their veneration of the virgin is becoming more and more blasphemous, the Saviour being degraded, and the virgin exalted in his place. ... “[T]he faithful” were furnished with a prayer, addressed to the “virgin conceived without sin,” in order that it might be pasted on their doors as a preservative against the cholera. They were also provided with a prayer, in which the interposition of the virgin... and the mediation of the one Mediator dispensed with. To counteract this in some measure, I composed a prayer for the use of our people: “Let us return unto the Lord; for he hath torn, and he will heal us.”

Meanwhile, in the worldview and evangelism of the Dominican Order, the Virgin Mary had held merely a special though particularly important symbolic status. This is best exemplified by the Holy Rosary, which is held by the Dominicans to be the complete form of Christian prayer, initially given from God to Saint Dominic, the founder of the Order, through Mary’s intercession. Marian devotion was essential for and inseparable from their devout service to God.

By the turn of the 20th century, *La Divina Pastora* in Siparia gave rise to much debate among the clerics. In 1901, *The Churchman*, a bulletin of anti-Catholic Anglican Church Association, reprinted a letter from a clergy in Trinidad who attended the Feast in Siparia of that year:

Mariolatry, in spite of all the safeguards and distinctions that casuistical theology may draw between *Latria* and *Doulia*, is not very far from superstition. This was strangely, if it were not for the pathos of the thing we would almost say amusingly, illustrated in a letter from Trinidad in the British West Indies recently published in *The Evening Post*. Here in the town of Siparia is a famous Spanish shrine of The Divine Shepherdess, La Divina Pastora. Pilgrims may be found here every day in the year, but the great festival is from Easter Monday to the Saturday of that week. A pagan festival essentially, with little prayer or religious service of any kind, but with infinite feasting and revelry in which Brahmin, Mohammedan, Confucianist and Romanist join in a catholic equality, all doing homage to the goddess who has indeed become all things to all men. Indeed, this is perhaps the only shrine in the world where Hindoo, Moslem, Chinese, Creole, Negro and Caucasian join in a worship whose creed has but one article—the beneficent power of the Divina Pastora, whom some call Mary and others Kali. This power is invoked in case of sickness, for the pangs of despised love, for success on the race course, and at the gambling bank. It is a brown-faced, slender image about three feet high, studded thick with jewels, that literally cover her white satin robe, in which she is supposed to make excursions into the forest for solitary communion with the Great Spirit. Curiously enough, there is no priest here. It is a purely spontaneous affair.

This was promptly countered by a Dominican friar in Trinidad:

The writer of the article [in *Churchman*] evidently depended upon hearsay for the information that he has so generously emblazoned. Initiating his remarks with a ghastly pun upon devotion to the Blessed Virgin Mary, this “casuistical” discriminator between *Latria* and *Doulia* proceeds to “knock the eye” out of the Shrine itself. Siparia is the scene of an annual pilgrimage of Catholic Christians.... The ceremonies consist in the celebration of Mass by the pastor and the reception of the Sacraments of Penance and Holy Eucharist by probably four or five hundred pious Christians—not pagans. A procession, in which the image of our Lady is carried is a devotional practice on the Feast. Before returning peacefully to their respective homes these good people partake of a frugal repast on the roadside... Possibly they were overlooked in the motley crowd of “Brahmins, Mohammedans, Confucians and Romanists” who joined in “catholic equality, doing homage to the goddess.” The troop of Hindoos, Moslems, Chinese, Creoles, Negroes, and Caucasians which this imposing juggler has conjured up as an *admirable illustration of unity of faith in Mary’s intercession*, seem to be equally afflicted with the “pangs of despised love”... [T]he presence of some Brahmins, Confucianists and non-Catholics as interested and edified *spectators* of the devotions practiced in honor of Mary. ... [W]hen the light of divine faith is granted to the Brahmin and Confucianist, he certainly joins the Romanist on grounds of Catholic—Roman “Catholic equality”—and ceases to be a Brahmin or Confucianist. He is not content with imitations in religious worship; he is devoid of tricks peculiar to the Anglican ape.

The Mother Came to Town

For the Archdiocese, it was a well-timed and favorable development that the sanctuary of *La Divina Pastora* in Siparia was thronged with Hindus. From the early 1870s, the Dominicans carried out various missionary and charitable activities, which were generically known as the

“Coolie Mission,” for the former indentured laborers resettling in and around POS, in competition with Protestant missionaries. A mass of Hindu converts to Catholicism by the appeal of this Marian would be the best demonstration of the moral superiority of Catholicism as well as the orthodoxy of the Dominican Order.

In 1873, Fr. Marie-François Ribon, a French Dominican, launched a mission at East Dry River in the eastern outskirts of Port-of-Spain. From the late 1830s, the Catholic Church had focused on the east of the capital city, which had grown into the most deprived quarter in the colony with the settlement of former African slaves, the majority of whom were Catholics. From the mid-1860s, this once-Catholic dominated area transformed into the colony’s most competitive market for Christian evangelization with the resettlement of former South Asian indentured workers and immigration of working-class African migrants from neighboring islands who mostly followed the Protestant faiths. Located in East Dry River, the gateway to the archdiocese, Fr. Ribon set the goal of his mission to “attack paganism of the outcastes of India, especially from Madras” against expanding Protestant missions. For this cause, he consecrated his mission to *La Divina Pastora* and made it known “Siparia Hill” or “New Siparia.”

Fr. Marie-Bertrand Cothonay, who followed Fr. Ribon in the Coolie Mission in Trinidad after 1880, recorded about Fr. Ribon’s mission in more than oft-cited *Trinidad: Journal of Dominican Missions*.

In 1876, Fr. Ribon heard that Hindus in a village on Gros-Morne Hill, about half a mile east of Siparia Hill, had immolated a human child and would soon repeat it. To “stop [the] sacrilegious abomination,” he headed for the village with catechists who had converted from Hinduism and twelve apostles acted by students of the Siparia Hill convent school. On arrival, Fr. Ribon preached the gospel to the assembled in French, English, and the “language of Madras,” despite threats from a cutlass-wielding Brahmin *pujari*. The villagers stood in awe and eventually fled in disarray. From that day, immolation would no longer be performed in this village.

Following year, on Good Shepherd Sunday (that was April 15, 1877), Fr. Ribon returned to Gros-Morne with a large procession of his congregation in celebration of this “resounding

triumph over paganism.” At the head of the procession, fourteen children from the convent marched each carrying a crucifix, followed by more children each waving a small banner. Behind them were “coolies reciting the rosary in the language of Madras” and the “image of *La Divina Pastora* carried by six coolies on their shoulders.” The statue was richly adorned with ornaments, chiffons, and flowers, and accompanied by another group of “coolies singing hymns in Madras.” On returning from Gros-Morne, the procession climbed up and down Siparia Hill. Along the course, an array of “[Afro-]creoles” residing in the area were all out to join the parade and “Protestants were in awe of such a beautiful sight.” The congregation heard the Protestants saying “Look how beautiful it is! These Catholics have the secrets to beautiful ceremonies!” Amid singers and acolytes, Fr. Hyacinth Bariou, Superior of the Dominican mission in POS, gave the Litany of the Most Holy Virgin Mary in Latin and to a huge audience around the Chapel of Siparia Hill. Then, Fr. Ribon tried to speak to the congregation, but filled with joy and emotion, sobs choked his voice. He tried in vain to hide his tears, which drew tears from the eyes of the congregation and Protestants. At the conclusion of the Feast, Fr. Ribon offered prayer, saying “May Divine Shepherdess touch the hearts of so many poor pagans and bring them to the knowledge of the true faith.”

“All Things in Siparia for Siparians”

Toward initiating the Siparia Hill mission, Fr. Ribon had correspondence with then curate for Siparia Fr. Cornelius O’Hanlon. In the exchange, Fr. Ribon urged Fr. O’Hanlon to transfer a major portion of the money offerings and other valuable gifts received by *La Divina Pastora* in Siparia to the archdiocese. He also prompted Catholics in Siparia to start selling, instead of giving away free as they had done, curative holy unction known by the name of “La Divina Oil,” provided that full sales proceeds would be directed to the archdiocese.

The curates for Siparia were terrified and repulsed by the developments in devotion to *La Divina Pastora* in their parish. But, they implemented no measures to contain growing Hindu homage to the Marian image. Instead, “by the advice of Dominicans,” they strove to demythologize *La Divina Pastora*. From the perspective of the French and Irish Dominicans, this Marian image was idolized and its devotion was degraded into a transgressive, syncretic ritual due to the influence of Spanish folk Catholicism. So they worked to de-Hispanicize this Spanish-origin

Maria image so that it would represent a canonical form of intercessory evangelist in conformity to the Dominican Order's doctrine of faith and reason. This is reflected that the curates started showing strong concern over the appearance of the statue. For instance, in 1879, Fr. Armand Masse, the successor to O'Hanlon, was displeased with the dirty and miserable outlook of *La Divina Pastora* and scrambled to get the statue changed into a new dress to make it look less the "Spanish Virgin" and more the "Holy Virgin in Rome."

These demands from the Dominicans for the sake of the Coolie Mission were rejected by Siparian Catholics. The male parishioner in charge of the sanctuary refused to hand the curate the key to the collection box; while female caretakers resisted dressing the statue in new robe and gown other than at the time of Good Shepherd Sunday Mass.

Siparia had been "completely neglected" until the archdiocese turned to this remote mission reflecting Dominican concern with its patroness. The marginalization of Siparia was in part because of its location restricted by geographic conditions and undeveloped infrastructure; but more important because of its development as a reservoir of Spanish human capital and religiosity.

Exactly when Hindus began making devotion to the Marian statue in Siparia remains a matter of conjecture. It is certain however that they started to visit Siparia with generous gifts looking for miracles and cure by the statue despite its remoteness and ethnic alienation within the Catholic Church. Fr. Hyacinth Bariou, Superior of the Dominican mission in POS who officiated Good Shepherd Sunday Mass in 1874, wrote in his memoir:

The sanctuary of the "Divina Pastora," which gives Siparia its celebrity, is all that can be imagined of extreme poverty. It is built of bad "tapia," covered with miserable roofing of leaves. Its walls are of but little height, and clumsily made. So much for the exterior. The interior is not less wretched: you walk on the bare ground, beaten to dust so as not to injure the pilgrims' feet, though the sanctuary is floored. The altar is simplicity itself. The statue of the "Divina Pastora" is certainly not the work of an artist; but to make amends it is richly adorned. Every year a gift is made to it of one or two robes, and the cure assured us that it had now more than seventy. Offerings are also made of lamps, chandeliers, bracelets, vases of all kinds, and even dolls, earrings, and watches...

Who gives all [these] presents? Perhaps you think that it is the rich inhabitants of the country; but if so you are mistaken. Except the chasuble and chalice, given by inhabitants of Port-of-Spain, all the rest have been given at different times by the Chinese and "Coolies."

Siparian Catholics had, materially and spiritually, lived off gifts that came through the appeal of *La Divina Pastora*, regardless of the giver's religious identity. In this period of financial crisis, Siparia completed the first presbytery and rebuilt the chapel. Besides, it was customary for the curates to purchase liturgical items and church furnishing with the money for which they sold gifts to *La Divina Pastora*. And the curates also remade dresses donated to *La Divina Pastora* into their vestments and clerical clothing.

[When he arrived in Siparia in 1861], there was a miserable hut called a Church; we have now a splendid one... [And] since the time of the old Spanish Fathers, I am the first Curè living in his own Presbytery.

Fr. Cornelius O'Hanlon, 1879

According to the Spanish Custom the statue is dressed with very costly robes, but having too many of them, with the advice of the Dominican Fathers, I carried several to Port of Spain, and made some five vestments of them, as we had only two old vestments. A ciborium has also been procured.

Fr. Cornelius O'Hanlon, 1873

No historical record supports the fact that measures were ever taken to remove *La Divina Pastora* from Siparia. But, Siparian Catholics harbored strong distrust that their patroness would be spirited out of their community in due course. Their suspicion translated into intimidation and harassment against the curates. For instance, two Siparian Catholics insulted a number of times and kicked Fr. O'Hanlon on one occasion, and later seized the bridle of Fr. Masse's horse and beat him. In the late 1880s, an acting curate replacing Fr. Masse "had to disperse Siparian rowdies and make them leave the bridle of his horse with his revolver." Finally, on New Year's Eve of that year, a party of ten Siparian Catholics "entered the Church with the object of carrying away the Divina Pastora statue, but they were prevented by the Constables" at the request of Fr. Aloysius Osenda, the-then curate for Siparia.

According to the baptismal records, prior to this incident, one of the would-be thieves uttered threats against Fr. Osenda upon his arrival in the parish: "All things in Siparia for Siparians! No priest, no bishop, no governor here."

To "Canalize [rather] than to Stop"

As soon as he assumed the archbishopric in 1909, Fr. Dowling undertook the revitalization of the now defunct Coolie Mission. For this purpose, he had an eye to embracing *La Divina Pastora* of

Siparia, not *La Divina Pastora* of Siparia Hill, at the archdiocese's discretion, given the fact that Siparia had been promoted from a pastoral district of South Oropouche to a parish with resident priest.

In 1910, Vicar General Fr. Vincent Sutherland, who was named by Fr. Dowling to head the reconstruction of the Coolie Mission, performed a field survey in Boissiere Village. This community north of POS was comparable to East Dry River in the late 19th century as a concentration of former indentured South Asians, particularly those from southern India. Based on the findings, Fr. Sutherland suggested to Fr. Dowling "if the chapel at Siparia were transferred to Boissiere Village, a lot of useful work could be done for Indians."

Meanwhile, Fr. Dowling stepped up his call on Fr. Osenda, the parish priest for Siparia, to exclude Hindus from the celebration of *La Divina Pastora*. But, Fr. Osenda did not implement required actions. More accurately, he could not do so because of the resistance from his parishioners rather than from the Hindu devotees. The following letter from Fr. Osenda to Fr. Dowling indicates that the increasing pressure from the archdiocese put him in a very difficult situation.

[C]ertainly I was sorry to find that customs here and if it was in my power I had suppressed longtimes; but in the circumstances, I tried to suppress the abuses, try little by little to discourage the Coolies, not because I think that there is any desecration of Church, but because this fete is always a great worry for me; and I would be thankful if it could be suppressed, but in my opinion, I believe that is better to canalize the water than to stop it all at once.

Fr. Modeste Osenda, 1915

In the following two year, 1916 and 1917, at the request of the archdiocese, the governor issued a state ban on the annual Hind pilgrimage to Siparia.

Siparia was never demoted from a parish. But, its autonomy was restricted between the late 1910s and the late 1920s. First, in 1912, Dowling appointed Fr. Sutherland as the parish priest for South Oropouche and placed Deve and Penal, then pastoral districts of Siparia, under his jurisdiction. In 1915, Fr. Sutherland proposed Fr. Dowling to detain Fr. Osenda, who did not comply with the request from the archdiocese and instead made "canalize-rather-than stop" proposal. Second, from 1914, Fr. Dowling stationed three Benedictine brothers at Erin. The

Abbey was founded two years earlier by a group of Benedictines from Brazil under the patronage of the archdiocese provided it would contribute to evangelizing South Asians, especially Hindus, in the colony. The previous studies, including my own paper, have documented that a “parish priest” locked all doors of the sanctuary to discourage Hindus from their homage, but was eventually compelled to let them in because the Hindus threatened to burn the chapel down. But, in fact, in 1928, Brother Anselm Romano, Benedictine at Erin, who had acted as Interim parish priest for Siparia at the request of Fr. Dowling, attempted to crowd Hindu pilgrims out of the sanctuary. His attempt failed more because of the opposition from lay Catholics in Siparia. Indeed, shortly after the incident, a written petition was addressed to Dowling, objecting to curacy of Benedictine monks and requesting the prompt appointment of a resident priest for the parish.

La Divina Pastora as the Sorrowful Mother

Since the fall of the Siparia Hill mission, its patroness, *La Divina Pastora* had also fallen into oblivion. But, in 1917, a few months after the Hindu pilgrimage took place despite the state ban, the Virgin Mary appeared to this *La Divina Pastora* now standing at the Church of the Holy Trinity in Arouca. On October 5 of the year, about two hundred parishioners witnessed the following “extraordinary [and] undeniable fact”:

The statue was placed in the middle of the church of Arouca for the Triduum of prayers preceding the pilgrimage to Tacarigua. About half past two o’clock on the eve of the pilgrimage which was about to be made in honour of the Mother of God to obtain “Peace” through her powerful intercession, a group of little ones from the Convent school went in the church to pray before the statue and were astonished to see tears flowing from the eyes of Our Blessed Lady. Trembling with emotion, some ran to call nuns while the others continued to pray aloud. One of the sisters went with the children to the church and was amazed to find the statue weeping. She went immediately to call the other sister. Soon the Schoolmaster, teachers, pupils and about two hundred persons of every denomination were there to witness the undeniable fact. The tears continued to flow quite naturally until about five o’clock. The Sisters, joined by the faithful, continued to recite the Rosary and offer prayers aloud all the time. Unfortunately, the Parish Priest was absent on the occasion.

Like Erin, Arouca had been under the charge of the Benedictine fathers since 1914, and at which time Mary appeared, its parish priest was Rev. Ambrose Vinckier, one of the three founding brothers of the Abbey. A few weeks before the apparition, at Brother Vinckier’s invitation, Fr. Dowling officiated Mass at the Church of the Holy Trinity, and he recounted a “history of the

ancient statue of ‘La Divina Pastora,’ formerly honoured in the Church of Siparia Hill” to the assembled who “[knew] nothing about it.”

Following the apparition, Brother Vinckier sent a letter requesting for permission from the archdiocese to establish Arouca Society of La Divina Pastora for the cause of the Catholic evangelism for Hindus and Protestants. Enclosed in this letter was the photograph of the statue.

Humbly kneeling before you, I ask your fatherly blessing. Here the statutes included command of a new society that want to establish in this parish of Arouca in honor of the Blessed Mary under the title “The Divina Pastora.” The devotion to the Divina Pastora is growing rapidly and the parishioners are desirous of permission to set up a society in which they can devote themselves entirely and even publicly to the Virgin Mary. Exceeding great are the favors received through the intercession of the Divina Pastora; to her is attached without the slightest doubt a great number of conversions of Protestants and Indians. ... [T]he statute shall be fully applicable for the conversion of the Indians. ... Hoping Your Grace will approve these statutes for the greater honor and glory of the Blessed Mary and in favor of the parish of Arouca.

Brother Ambrose Vinckier, 1918

The Power of Mary in Colonial Trinidad

The year of 1917 marked a critical juncture in the history of Marian devotion. From May of that year, the Mary had monthly appeared in Fátima, Portugal. The Blessed Virgin made her sixth and last monthly appearance on October 13th, a week after the apparition in Arouca. In a few decades, *Nossa Senhora do Fátima*, or Our Lady of Fátima, grew into the object of worldwide Marian devotion.

Successor to Fr. Dowling, Archbishop Finber Ryan was known for his devout faith in Our Lady of Fatima. On arriving in Trinidad in 1940, he published a book, *Our Lady of Fatima* [The foreword to the book was contributed by Fr. Dowling].

In 1943, Archbishop Finber Ryan consecrated the Archdiocese of POS to the Immaculate Heart of Mary and called Laventille Hill the National Shrine dedicated to Our Lady of Fatima. By that time, the apparition had not apparently empowered *La Divina Pastora* of Arouca as venerable enough to replace *La Divina Pastora* of Siparia. Around the same time as the dedication of the Shrine of Laventille to Our Lady of Fatima, *La Divina Pastora* of Arouca, who could not deliver the aspiration of the archdiocese for evangelism, was removed from the Church of the Holy

Trinity to a humble oratory in Lopinot, a desolate, mountainous village and pastoral district of Arouca—as if to forget the archdiocese ever longed for and went after *La Divina Pastora*.

In 1957, at the 40th anniversary of the apparition at Fatima, Archbishop Ryan said to the assembled at the Shrine of Laventille: “There are people living today who can recall that in the very week Our Lady was appearing in Fatima, persons saw an apparition in Trinidad of Our Lady weeping.” His homily did not refer to the name of *La Divina Pastora*—as if to impress that the Virgin Mary appeared to Our Lady of Fatima.

La Divina Pastora is so attractive—attractive for different groups for their competing political and spiritual sakes. The Dominican-led archdiocese was attracted to this Marian image as it had attracted to “pagan Coolies.” Fr. Ribon was inspired to start his Coolie Mission in the archdiocese in the name of *La Divina Pastora*. But, it is arguable whether South Asians in his congregation at Siparia Hill really made devotion to *La Divina Pastora* as a Marian image. Fr. Cothonay, who recorded about Fr. Ribon’s “triumph over paganism,” also questioned this point describing how “Coolies” in Siparia Hill celebrated the Feast:

This year [1877] it was an incomparable splendor. Coolies prepared in advance: they cut loads of bamboos, and on the eve of the festival, they planted them on both sides of the road leading to the chapel. At the top of each bamboo floated a banner with bright colors. They had built the chapel to a spacious tent made of bamboo and coconut leaves artistically plaited. Inside the chapel, she [La Divina Pastora] was decorated with flowers and fruits of the country. Hanging around a big banana regime.

The coolies appear to be very proud of this tent, which reminded them of those they built in their country for solemnities of their gods for family celebration! As a small chapel, which had just been painted new, she had been adorned with various colors of muslin, candles, and flowers. It really was an air of festival.

Fr. Marie-Bertrand Cothonay, 1887

In fact, Fr. Ribon’s Siparia Hill was not so “triumphant” in proselytizing Hindus as emphasized by his colleague, Fr. Cothonay. Contrary to the intention of the Dominican fathers, *La Divina Pastora* erected with a view to convert Hindus to Catholicism might have rather helped *La Divina Pastora* in still distant Siparia gain publicity among Hindus in northern and central Trinidad.

It is wrong to assume that the Catholic devotion to *La Divina Pastora* was an established custom like one we observe today before Hindus started to pay homage to this Marian image. Siparia has its roots in a Capuchin mission dedicated to *La Divina Pastora*, which was founded in the late 1750s. But, non-Catholic, particularly Hindu, pilgrimage and daily supplication and flow of gifts to Siparia in dire straits have invested this Marian image with new spirituality, and transformed its celebration into an unprecedented new form. An apt example comes from curative holy unction known as “La Divina Oil.” Fr. Bariou, Dominican Superior, wrote about the oil in 1876:

Have there been any miracles at Siparia? ... I can answer upon authentic proofs, Yes. A great number of cures, if not evidently miraculous, at least extraordinary, have been and are worked every day by the oil of six or seven lamps which continually burn before the “Divina Pastora.” During the these days of the feast which I passed at Siparia, I saw several persons actually take this oil; it could them be obtained in abundance, as more than fifty lamps were burning night and day before the miraculous image.... By simply rubbing the part affected with the oil of the “Divina Pastora,” the parish priest himself [Fr. O’Hanlon] was cured of a pain in the leg, from which he had suffered for twelve years, and which often prevented him from walking. The Hindoo and Chinese inhabitants of the country, and even those of them who are still pagans, are so accustomed to these cures that they look upon the oil as a sovereign and universal remedy. It is true that they mingle a little superstition with their faith, but if we could only have a little hermitage at Siparia, we should be able by little and little to destroy these superstitions, and as I think, to convert a great number of pagans.

Fr. Hyacinth Bariou, 1876

On Feast day, as a part of their devotion, pilgrims, both Catholics and non-Catholics, brought oils and poured them into burning lamps set before *La Divina Pastora*. And then, they collected oils from the same lamps and took them home in the faith that they had curative power. Although well aware of the fact that the oil was made of donations from non-Catholics, not only lay Catholics but also parish priests believed in the healing properties of this unction taken from the same lamps and used it to treat whatever their conditions.

There is little documentation concerning how the statue was cared and celebrated in the late 18th and early 19th century. But it is doubtful that *La Divina Pastora* was looked after as well as after this image became a venerable object more widely including from Hindus. If Fr. O’Hanlon’s statement is correct, there had not existed a home for *La Divina Pastora* in the sanctuary until he introduced the “first altar” for the image in 1872.

The *La Divina Pastora* devotion that we observe in Siparia today has developed with ritual practices, objects, and worldviews of non-Catholic devotees as its integral part. The Catholic and

Hindu devotions to the image have been reproduced as antithetic within the context of the concurrent politics of orthodoxy. Simultaneously however, they have together formed an integrative whole and created a “nascent religion that is, in a real sense, its own” if following Sydney Mintz and Richard Price’s time-honored statement.

Today, parishioners in Siparia and Catholic devotees call the statue by the name of *La Divin*. This sobriquet is for sure derived from *La Divina Pastora*, the Marian image of Spanish origin. But, *La Divin* is distinct from *La Divina Pastora* more than nominally. Entangled politics of orthodox and pragmatics for daily spiritual and material needs have empowered this statue as historically- and spatially-specific, thus irreplaceable image of *La Divin*. Blind to this transformation, the Dominican-led archdiocese strove to mobilize the statue in Siparia for the cause of its evangelization as a timeless, spaceless, universal *La Divina Pastora* divorced from the context of empowerment and production.

But this does not mean that Siparian Catholics have held control over this Marian image. Particularly from the early 20th century, they have always been driven by contradictory desires to avow Hindu (and non-Catholic) devotions to the statue while also disavowing the implications of their ethnoreligiousness for *La Divin*. In order to accommodate the competing desires, they have made the statue available for Catholic and Hindu homage on different dates, at different places, and in different dresses. Together with consistent Hindu adoration, Catholics pragmatic measures to “canalize [rather] than to stop” objectionable religious influence have transformed the statue into an agentic and indexical object. *La Divin* has gained personhood as if she accommodates contradictory spiritual needs without contradiction changing her dress and walking across religious boundaries on her own will and initiative. *La Divin* is powerfully attractive not because she questions and deconstructs the boundaries, but rather because she is embedded in the social and material networks of Trinidad and thereby rendered her more real, more cogent, and more interiorized. The present female caretakers unanimously remind:

“We belong to her, not the other way around.”